

KNOW BEFORE YOU GO

2026 AWS-MLU AI Teaching & Research Symposium

September 21–22, 2026 · Tech Casual — Represent Your Campus! 🎓

Howard University | Day 1 · Amazon HQ2 | Day 2

WELCOME

We are so excited to welcome you to the 2026 AWS Machine Learning University AI Teaching and Research Symposium & Poster Session! Over two extraordinary days, you’ll connect with nearly 500 students, faculty, executives, and technology leaders from community colleges, HBCUs, and other institutions — all united by a shared mission to advance AI teaching and innovation.

Here’s everything you need to know before you arrive.

AT A GLANCE

	Day 1	Day 2
Date	Monday, September 21, 2026	Tuesday, September 22, 2026
Location	Howard University	Amazon HQ2
Venue	Armour J. Blackburn Center	Aurora Building (WAS16)
Address	2397 6th St NW, Washington, DC 20059	1770 Crystal Drive, Arlington, VA 22202
Floors	Blackburn Ballroom & Breakout Rooms	14th Floor (Sessions) · 13th Floor (Posters & Lunch)
Hosts	Jamila Hashil & Joe Briggs	Joe Briggs, Jamila Hashil, & Joi Spears
Check-in Opens	8:30 AM	9:00 AM
Program Begins	9:30 AM	9:30 AM

ATTIRE

Tech Casual — Represent Your Campus! 🎓

Wear your campus colors, your school polo, your institution’s gear, or your favorite tech-casual look. This is your moment to show where you’re from and what you stand for. Come comfortable, come confident, and come ready to build.



WEAR COMFORTABLE SHOES!

You’ll be on your feet throughout the day — walking between sessions, exploring poster presentations, and touring Amazon HQ2. Trust us on this one. Your feet will thank you.

SET UP AMAZON QUICK BEFORE YOU ARRIVE

Before you arrive, please set up Amazon Quick — Amazon’s AI Agent. You’ll use it during hands-on sessions at the symposium.



Get started here: quick.aws.com/sn?utm_campaign=mlu2026

- Quick is free to set up and use.
- Follow the instructions at the link above to create your account.
- If you run into any issues, the Amazon team will be available on-site to help.
- Having Quick ready before you arrive will help you hit the ground running.

DAY 1 — MONDAY, SEPTEMBER 21, 2026

Howard University | Armour J. Blackburn Center

2397 6th St NW, Washington, DC 20059

Schedule Overview

Time	Session	Location
8:30 – 9:30 AM	Registration, Check-in & Breakfast	Blackburn Ballroom
9:30 – 10:50 AM	Opening Plenary	Blackburn Ballroom
11:00 AM – 12:30 PM	Breakout Sessions	By Track (see below)

KNOW BEFORE YOU GO		2026 AWS-MLU AI Symposium
Time	Session	Location
12:30 – 1:30 PM	Lunch	Blackburn Ballroom
1:30 – 3:00 PM	Breakout Sessions (continued)	By Track (see below)
3:15 – 4:00 PM	Closing Plenary & Gen AI Shark Tank	Blackburn Ballroom
4:00 – 4:10 PM	Closing Remarks	Blackburn Ballroom
4:10 – 4:40 PM	Byte-Size Connections Networking Hour	Blackburn Ballroom
4:40 PM	Optional Campus Tours	Howard University

Your Breakout Track

Please report to your assigned breakout room at 11:00 AM sharp.

Note: The Executive Administrator and CIO tracks have been combined for breakout sessions.

Track	Who	Location
 Cloud Connect	Students	Blackburn Center, Gallery Lounge
 Educators Consortium	Faculty	Blackburn Ballroom
 Transformation Alliance & Visionary Tech Collaborative	Executive Administrators & CIOs	Blackburn Center, Reading Lounge

Meals — Day 1

- ☒ Breakfast provided | 8:30 – 9:30 AM | Blackburn Ballroom
- ☒ Lunch provided | 12:30 – 1:30 PM | Blackburn Ballroom

DAY 2 — TUESDAY, SEPTEMBER 22, 2026

Amazon HQ2 | Aurora Building (WAS16)

1770 Crystal Drive, Arlington, VA 22202

 **Parking Notice for Poster Presenters:** Free parking is not available at HQ2. Rideshare or metro are strongly recommended. Please plan accordingly.

Important: Registration Required

All attendees must have completed registration prior to arrival. This is required for Amazon building access. **No exceptions.**

Floor Guide

14th Floor — All general sessions, keynotes, and the Faculty Recognition Ceremony

13th Floor — Student & Faculty Poster Sessions and Lunch (Dining Hall)

Schedule Overview

Time	Session	Location
8:30 AM	Breakfast & Check-in	13th Floor / WAS16 Lobby
9:30 – 9:38 AM	Opening Remarks: Dr. Margie Vela	14th Floor
9:39 – 9:50 AM	Career Choice: Yuanxia Ding	14th Floor
9:51 – 10:21 AM	AWS Developer Experience: Lisa Bagley	14th Floor
10:22 – 10:52 AM	Amazon BEN-Tech in Higher Education: Willie Mays & Lisa Chandler	14th Floor
10:53 – 10:55 AM	Poster Session Introduction: Joi Spears	14th Floor
10:55 AM – 12:15 PM	Student & Faculty Poster Sessions (hors d'oeuvres provided)	13th Floor
12:15 PM	Lunch	13th Floor, Dining Hall
1:10 – 1:41 PM	Amazon Internships: Michael Hoggard & Antionna Sudor	14th Floor
1:41 – 2:05 PM	Faculty Recognition Ceremony	14th Floor
2:05 – 2:10 PM	Closing Remarks: Dr. Vita Pickrum	14th Floor
2:10 – 3:30 PM	Optional Tours	See below

Meals — Day 2

- ☒ Breakfast provided | 8:30 AM | 13th Floor, WAS16
- ☒ Breakfast provided | 8:30 AM | 13th Floor, WAS16
- ☒ Hors d'oeuvres provided during poster sessions | 10:56 AM – 12:16 PM | 13th Floor
- ☒ Lunch provided | 12:15 PM | 13th Floor, Dining Hall

POSTER SESSIONS — DAY 2

13th Floor, WAS16 | 10:55 AM – 12:15 PM

The poster session is digital only — please do not bring paper posters.

Poster Presenter Instructions

Arrive at your designated station on the 13th floor by your assigned group time:

- **Group 1: Ready by 10:55 AM**
 - **Group 2: Ready by 11:15 AM**
 - **Group 3: Ready by 11:35 AM**
 - **Group 4: Ready by 11:55 AM**
-
- Bring your own laptop or presentation device
 - Bring any proprietary HDMI adapters you need
 - LCD screens, laptop stands, and HDMI/USB-C connections will be provided. Screens are not touch-enabled.
 - Accepted file formats: PowerPoint, PDF, PNG
 - Upload a PDF backup of your poster to the shared OneDrive link provided in your acceptance email

This is your moment to share the work you've been doing.

Last year's digital posters: <https://awsmachinelearninguniversity.virtualpostersession.org/>

Optional Tours (2:10 – 3:30 PM)

Tours are first-come, first-served. Check with tour coordinators at the exits for availability and directions.

Tour	Host	Details
 AI Experience Center @ HQ2	Precious Tate	Open tour · Limited capacity
 AWS Skills Center	Gerry Brooks	Open tour & networking · Unlimited capacity
 HQ2 Guided Tour	HQ2 Team	Guided walking tour of Amazon's headquarters campus

TRAVEL GUIDE: GETTING THERE

By Air

Recommended: DCA — Ronald Reagan Washington National Airport is the closest airport with direct Metro access to both venues.

Airport	Distance to Howard	Distance to HQ2	Notes
DCA ★	5 miles (~15 min)	3 miles (~10 min)	Metro accessible
IAD (Dulles)	27 miles (~45 min)	24 miles (~40 min)	No direct Metro

Airport	Distance to Howard	Distance to HQ2	Notes
BWI (Baltimore)	33 miles (~50 min)	30 miles (~45 min)	MARC Train available

P Parking

⚠️ Parking is very limited at both venues — we strongly recommend using rideshare (Uber/Lyft) or Metro instead of driving.

🏠 Near Howard University (Day 1): Nearby garages on Georgia Avenue NW (~\$10/day). Limited street parking (metered).

🏠 Near Amazon HQ2 (Day 2): Nearby garages on Crystal Drive (~\$23/day). Free parking is not available at HQ2.

🚇 Metro (Strongly Recommended)

To Howard University (Day 1):

- Take the Green or Yellow Line to Shaw-Howard University Station
- From DCA: Yellow Line northbound (~20 min)
- From Union Station: Green Line northbound (~5 min)

To Amazon HQ2 — WAS16 (Day 2):

- Take the Blue or Yellow Line to Crystal City Station
- From DCA: Yellow Line northbound — just one stop (~2 min)
- From Union Station: Yellow Line southbound (~15 min)
- Exit and walk south along Crystal Drive to 1770 Crystal Drive (~5 min walk)

🚗 Rideshare (Uber/Lyft)

Widely available at all three airports.

From	To Howard	To Amazon HQ2
DCA	\$15–\$25	\$10–\$15
IAD	\$55–\$75	\$50–\$70
BWI	\$65–\$85	\$70–\$90

RECOMMENDED HOTELS

Near Howard University (Day 1)

Hotel	Distance
The LINE DC	1.5 miles

KNOW BEFORE YOU GO		2026 AWS-MLU AI Symposium
Hotel		Distance
Cambria Hotel Washington, DC Convention Center		1.2 miles
Hilton Washington DC National Mall		4 miles
Hampton Inn Washington DC NoMa Union Station		2 miles
Marriott Marquis Washington, DC		1.5 miles

Near Amazon HQ2 (Day 2)

★ *Recommended* — Embassy Suites Crystal City and Crystal Gateway Marriott are both connected to the Crystal City Metro underground, offer complimentary airport shuttles, and are within walking distance of WAS16.

Hotel		Distance
Embassy Suites Crystal City ★		0.3 miles
Crystal Gateway Marriott ★		0.4 miles
Crowne Plaza Crystal City		0.2 miles
Hyatt Regency Crystal City		0.7 miles
Courtyard Crystal City/Reagan National		0.8 miles

 **Government Rate Tip:** Employees of public institutions may qualify for the government rate with a valid institutional ID. Check with the hotel when booking.

IMPORTANT LOGISTICS

Topic	Details
 For your Safety	Registration and ID check are required for AWS HQ2 entry. No exceptions.
 Wi-Fi	Guest Wi-Fi available at both venues. Details shared on-site.
 Travel Support	Travel support is NOT available for this event. Please work with your institution for travel funding.
 Meals	Breakfast & lunch provided on Day 1. Hors d'oeuvres & lunch provided on Day 2.
 Attire	Tech Casual — Represent Your Campus!

Topic	Details
 Check-in	Have your confirmation email (sent with this document) ready each morning.
 Event Website	https://mlu-ai-symposium.com/

EXPLORING WASHINGTON, D.C.

Howard University is located in the vibrant U Street/Shaw corridor — one of D.C.'s most culturally rich neighborhoods. Take some time to explore:

-  U Street restaurants and cultural venues (0.5 miles)
-  The National Mall and Smithsonian museums (2.5 miles via Metro)
-  Dupont Circle (1.5 miles)
-  Georgetown (3 miles)

CONTACT & KEY LINKS

Event Organizer	Dr. Margie Vela — velmarg@amazon.com
Operations Lead	Joi Spears — joilyns@amazon.com
Event Website	https://mlu-ai-symposium.com/
Student Poster Submission	Closed- FAQs at: https://mlu-ai-symposium.com/students
Faculty Poster Submission	Closed- FAQs at: https://mlu-ai-symposium.com/faculty
Last Year's Digital Posters	https://awsmllearninguniversity.virtualpostersession.org/

We can't wait to see you there.

Represent your campus, bring your energy, and get ready for two incredible days of innovation, connection, and celebration.

Understand Deeply. Think Critically. Build Intelligently.

— Dr. Margie Vela & Joi Spears, AWS Machine Learning University